The Role of Della

By John Wooten

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: An acting audition can cause a lot of stress for aspiring actors and actresses. Finding a good acting audition can be hard enough, getting invited to an audition is even harder, and the actual act of auditioning for the role is sometimes the biggest moment of an actor's life. So here are some tips:

ACTRESS 2: The judges will look into more than just your facial expressions. Basics, such as, were you on time? Did you show an extravagant personality when you were walking into the room? Make them remember your name!

ACTRESS 1: Use your own creativity to do this (be professional, don't go crazy), but there's something to be said about making a lasting impression on someone. If it's close between you and another star actor or actress then it could be your ace in the hole.

ACTRESS 2: Make sure you follow direction well. You will be so focused on your own monologue or whatever you have to do for your audition that you might forget an important factor. Listen to your casting director during your acting audition!

ACTRESS 1: As long as you are sure your casting director is REALLY a casting director. (with a look at Actress 2)

TOGETHER: The Role of Della by John Wooten

Lights up on an audition studio. EMMA stands in front if a table. She carefully examines a few head shots, which are spread about the table. She notices one if interest and slowly sits down in a chair in front if the table. ELIZABETH slowly sticks her head into the room.

ELIZABETH: Excuse me. *(Startled, Emma quickly puts the head shot on the table. She begins to rise.)* No, don't get up. I'm a little early. There was no monitor out front.

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I saw the door open. I didn't know if I should come straight in ... or if I should wait ... I'll come back in a few minutes. *(Starts out)*

EMMA: Do you have your audition card?

ELIZABETH: Oh, yeah. *(With a smile.)* I wouldn't lose this. I had to get here at 6 A.M. to wait in line and I still barely got a slot. Some girl offered me fifty dollars for this card. Just for a chance to audition. It's like a zoo out there.

EMMA: Hand it to me, please.

ELIZABETH: Sure. *(She crosses to her. Offers hand.)* I must say it's a great pleasure to meet you, Ms. Stewart. I've heard great things about your theatre.

EMMA: *(Shakes hand.)* Thank you. The card.

ELIZABETH: Oh, right. *(She hands Emma the audition card.)* Sorry. Just a little nervous.

EMMA: That's all right. I understand.

ELIZABETH: John Wyatt says hello.

EMMA: Really.

ELIZABETH: He's doing great. He just booked ...

EMMA: Do you have a head shot and resume?

ELIZABETH: Of course. *(She hands* EMMA *her resume.)*

EMMA: *(Takes a moment, looks at the headshot.)* No, I need your headshot. (ELIZABETH *laughs.)* Is something funny?

ELIZABETH: I don't understand.

EMMA: *(Deliberately slow.)* I need your headshot.

ELIZABETH: This is my headshot.

EMMA: No.

ELIZABETH: Yes, that's me.

EMMA: Really? You've gained a few pounds since this picture was taken, haven't you?

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ELIZABETH: I beg your pardon?

EMMA: What role are you interested in?

ELIZABETH: Della.

EMMA: Della? Really? The young ingenue?

ELIZABETH: *(A beat.)* Yes.

EMMA: *(Chuckles to herself.)* Okay. Why not. What piece are you doing?

ELIZABETH: Uh ... Today, I

EMMA: Can you move back a little, please?

ELIZABETH: Sure. Sorry. *(She moves back, away from table.)* Good morning. My name is Elizabeth Ryan. Today, I will be doing a selection from ...

EMMA: Just do the monologue.

ELIZABETH: Right.

EMMA: You only have two minutes, you know?

ELIZABETH: Yes. *(She turns and takes a breath. She turns back around, and begins.)* "Oh, we would get into terrible arguments, my mother and I."

EMMA: Do I have something on my face?

ELIZABETH: Pardon?

EMMA: Why are you looking at me?

ELIZABETH: Is it okay if I direct my piece to you?

EMMA: What do you think?

ELIZABETH: *(Begins again, awkwardly directing piece to chair.)* "Once, when I was twelve or thirteen, I told her that God was a moronic fairy tale-I think I'd spent an entire night ... "

EMMA: Do you have anything else?

ELIZABETH: Excuse me?

EMMA: Do you have another monologue? (ELIZABETH *looks confused.)* Anything? ... I've already heard that twice today.

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ELIZABETH: Really?

EMMA: Yes, and I was glad Agnes killed the baby.

ELIZABETH: *(Taken aback.)* I'm sorry. If you'd like to give me a direction with it, I'd be happy to ...

EMMA: This is not an acting class, Elizabeth. Besides, what you need is an interpretation class. *Agnes of God* is not a melodrama.

ELIZABETH: No, of course not. I wasn't trying to ...

EMMA: Don't make excuses. Just do something else.

ELIZABETH: I don't have anything else prepared. I thought that piece was appropriate.

EMMA: Actors do not think, Beth. They act. Those who think, think. Those who act, act. Those who think they can act, spend more time thinking than acting.

ELIZABETH: Of course. Can I please try again?

EMMA: No. Tell me a story ... Something funny.

ELIZABETH: Funny?

EMMA: Yes. Make me laugh.

ELIZABETH: Just like that?

EMMA: You want this job, don't you? You want to play Della?

ELIZABETH: Of course.

EMMA: Then make me laugh. Are you an actress or aren't you?

ELIZABETH: Okay ... Let's see ... When I was a little girl, my friend Carol and I found this old doll's house in her attic. We sneaked it carefully downstairs and cleaned it off. Carol had a pet mouse, Binkey. So we dressed Binkey up in this white Barbie dress and ...

EMMA: *(Ignoring her.)* So, I see here that you've listed Sandy in *Grease* as one of your credits.

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ELIZABETH: Oh, yes. It was a great experience. Working with Paul Jones. Do you know him?

EMMA: Didn't anyone ever tell you not to lie on your resume?

ELIZABETH: I didn't.

EMMA: Oh, come now.

ELIZABETH: I didn't. I swear I didn't.

EMMA: There's no character listing here by *The Glass Menagerie.* Was it done in the absurdist style or did you play the gentleman caller?

ELIZABETH: I played Laura.

EMMA: That must have been some time ago.

ELIZABETH: Last summer.

EMMA: I'm sorry, I didn't mean to interrupt your little story.

ELIZABETH: That's okay ... Uh, where was I ... So, after we dressed Binkey up in the Barbie costume, we placed him inside the doll house and he crawled right into the miniature bathroom as if he wanted to take a bath ...

EMMA: Add a Southern accent.

ELIZABETH: *(Adding a Southern accent.)* ... Then he got stuck in the miniature hall closet and we had to shake the doll house up and down and then Binkey popped out but he was all hyper and we couldn't catch him so he ran downstairs and Carol's mom was having this big ritzy dinner party and Binkey ran right at ...

EMMA: Let's see a little Spanish.

ELIZABETH: ... la grande jefe de mi madre, pero cuando la senorita jefe ...

EMMA: No. I don't want Spanish dialogue. I want a Spanish accent. Comprende?

ELIZABETH: Oh ... I can't do a Spanish accent.

EMMA: Then at least show me you have some energy ... Act the story out.

ELIZABETH: *(A beat. Elizabeth proceeds to act out everything she says.)* So, Carol's mother's

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boss screamed, leaped up onto the couch and pulled up her dress. Well, she wasn't wearing underwear ...

EMMA: Faster.

ELIZABETH: ... Then Carol's mother's boss's husband tried to grab her but instead he knocked her off into the double salsa sour cream dip and ...

EMMA: Faster!

ELIZABETH: ... and Binkey got scared and ran out into the front yard and the whole party went outside to look for him except Carol's mother's boss's husband and Carol's mother's boss who was crying, not because of the double salsa dip or even the flashing incident.

EMMA: No words!

ELIZABETH: Pardon?

EMMA: No words. *(Completely enthralled in the story, Elizabeth then acts out the rest of the story without words. This includes a chase scene, fainting, a cat, a dog, maybe even death. Elizabeth finishes with a loud laugh. She can't help but applaud herself.)*

EMMA: *(A beat. Dryly.)* Couldn't think of anything funny, huh?

ELIZABETH: *(A long beat. On the verge of tears)* Why are you being so rude to me.

EMMA: *(Innocently.)* Rude. Am I being rude? I'm sorry, Elizabeth. Please continue your quaint little rodent story.

ELIZABETH: I don't want to. I'm leaving.

EMMA: Leaving. You sure? You still have a few seconds left.

ELIZABETH: If you didn't think I was right for the role you should have just said so.

EMMA: Right? You're perfect. I just wanted to make sure you could handle all the terrible things Della must endure.

ELIZABETH: Really?

EMMA: Sure.

ELIZABETH: And?

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EMMA: There is no doubt in my mind that you think you would be perfect for this role. I don't think I've ever seen an actress quite like you before.

ELIZABETH: Thank you!

EMMA: But out of fairness I have to finish out the day. I'll call you tomorrow. Mind you, it will be late. Between midnight and 4 A.M. Make sure you're awake and by the phone. If you don't pick up after the first ring, I'll offer Della to someone else.

ELIZABETH: Don't worry. I won't sleep a wink.

EMMA: Good.

ELIZABETH: Anything I should know about the character? Keep in mind?

EMMA: Leave the wig at home. It doesn't fit.

ELIZABETH: Wig?

EMMA: And learn a Spanish accent and combine it with the Southern. You can talk faster too.

ELIZABETH: Even faster?

EMMA: Pace is everything.

ELIZABETH: Okay. I'll work on it tonight.

EMMA: Alright. Run along now. I'll be in touch ... (ELIZABETH *smiles and turns to go.)* Wait! Your number is 555-8798?

ELIZABETH: Yes.

EMMA: Just wanted to make sure.

ELIZABETH: Thank you. Thank you so much!

EMMA: No, thank you. (ELIZABETH *exits.* EMMA *watches her off. She picks up* ELIZABETH's *head shot, crosses to the waste basket and throws the head shot away, giggling to herself. A woman enters with coffee and takeout bag.)*

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SCENE

WOMAN: Hi, can I help you?

EMMA: *(Startled.)* Yes. *(A wide-eyed smile suddenly appears.)* Hi, I'm a little early. I saw the door open. Should I wait outside? ... I'll wait outside.

WOMAN: No, that's okay. Do you have your audition card?

EMMA: Yes. *(Hands her* ELIZABETH'S *card.)* Here you go ... I must say it's a pleasure to meet you, Ms. Stewart. I've heard great things about your theatre.

WOMAN: Well, thank you. We try.

EMMA: *(Trying to be sincere.)* John Wyatt says hello.

WOMAN: John! How is he?

EMMA: Great.

WOMAN: Do you have a picture for me?

EMMA: Sure do. *(Crosses to bag and pulls out her resume.)*

WOMAN: It's like a zoo out there.

EMMA: I know. I had to get here at 6 A.M. just to get an audition card. I didn't think I was going to get to see you. *(Elizabeth hands the woman her resume.)*

WOMAN: What piece are you doing?

EMMA: A short selection from Agnes of God.

WOMAN: *(Smiles.)* **In** that case, you better move back a few steps.

EMMA: Of course. *(Emma backs up.)* Good morning. My name is Emma Winns.

WOMAN: Wait ... Uh, what role would you like to be considered for, Emma?

EMMA: *(A beat.)* Della.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
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